Michael

By Daniel Steiger

The night was cold. Damp. The taste of salt hung in the air. Lamplights flickered over the edge of the railing that ran down the main street, overlooking a view of the open water that was never anything but blackness at this hour. The wind whipped up suddenly, a lone man stood staring out over the waves, the folds of his trenchcoat spun wildly while the wind lasted.

Moments after the wind had stirred, it disappeared just as abruptly. The man who stood watching was entirely unfazed by any of this, staring intently. There was a soft whispering coming from his lips. Michael was his name and he was here with a purpose. For many nights his dreams had drawn him to this spot, to this moment in time. Nightmares. Sounds of snarling beasts chasing him, the constant feeling of dread sinking in his stomach. Over the weeks he had died many times over. Died and come back once more once the morning light shone through his window. In every possible way a person can imagine Michael had died, the blending of reality with his nightmares consumed him. Michael now had a singular purpose. To die, to experience, to return. The whispers continued, a constant stream of wordless sound that felt as though it had the structure of language.

Lightning flashed in the distance. Far over the water another bolt struck down. Moments later the sound of thunder tore through the bleak night. There could be no more of a perfect emphasis for the nightmares.

The sound of thunder faded into nothing. Through it all Michaels whispers never slowed, never faltered. No longer was he part of the world as he once knew it. Now he was something far more. Lightning. The storm was rolling in quickly. Michael stared out over the water into it, knowing his fate this night was sealed. He had seen it many times before.

The nightmares. Always he found himself in this spot. This is where he always died. Would tonight be the same, he wondered. There was a nagging wonder if he would find himself here again, after this night.

The lightning flashed again, closer, familiar thunder shaking the core of the world.

There was no way to be certain anymore how long it had been since his dreams began. Weeks he had thought. Months perhaps. Everything had begun to blend together in a torrent of raw emotion, flooding his mind.

Lightning creased the sky directly overhead. Electricity coursed through the air, the sharp smell of it burned Michaels nose. Still, his wordless chant never subsided.

Storm clouds began to roll over his body, a dark fog creeping up from the depths. Lights in the lamps flickered and were suddenly still. This was a new nightmare.

Michael looked into the depths of the storm, lightning wreathed shapes that began to form from the blackness. Tendrils of darkness so complete it seemed as if they pulled in the light around, subduing all color.

Thunder shook Michael. Now it was constant, a feeling that was familiar, but in a way new. Something that seemed to have more substance than before.

The darkness over the water was closer now. The fetid stench of the creature grew stronger. A putrid slime hung about the air, coating and dripping from every surface, like dew on a tree.

Soft whispers in Michaels ear spoke a deep, grating language that no man could ever hope to understand. A dark laughter undercut everything said, as though many voices were speaking as one.

Voices like music, soft and faint. The sound kept Michael rooted as though a thousand tendrils wrapped his body in an unseen prison. His mouth could not open to scream, his eyes could not close to hide them from what was coming. What type of death would await him this night he wondered. What new torture would be devised, when all others failed to crack his mind.

There began a chittering in the back of Michaels mind, the voices became at first a hum and then a torrent as if a swarm of locusts circled his head. An unceasing deluge of sound threatening to chew him apart.

Lightning struck the ground next to him. Once to the left, again to the right. The voices began to take shape, amidst the chittering the whispers began to speak to him. Talking of all the ways he had been made to suffer over the weeks. Whispers of fire and darkness, blades and teeth.

Trying to hold onto the final remnants of his mind, Michael focused his eyes as best he could through the tendrils of darkness, through the slime, through the flashes of light in the fog over the water. With lightning coursing through the air in an unending torrent, Michael was able to make out a hard shape in the distance.

What seemed as if a moutain rising from the waters, bore down upon the waves with a fury repeating again and again. There were eyes, eyes everywhere upon what passed for skin.

Some were larger than a house while others were as small as blisters. The tendrils stuck to everything with row upon row of hellish mouths full of razor sharp teeth, rending the surface of everything they touched.

Michaels mind began to implode upon itself. The voices speaking of nothing but pain and suffering, the hold on him by those horrible teeth. A wordless scream tore through his motionless mouth. Echoing between the soft laughing and the crashing light his cries died as if they never were.

Silence echoed through the harbor, the horrid whispering voices ceased for a bleak and terrifying moment. Michael stared, crying a desparate plea to the creature. In answer the voices began again, harder, louder. Speaking now in unison, over and over, whispers and bellows, "Ma'shka, Ma'shka..." The amorphous body of eyes reared up, raising itself from the deep waters. "Ma'shka..." falling and rising.

Michael was grabbed by an unseen force. As if the air itself had congealed around him to lift him. Closer it brought him to the writhing mass, standing now taller than any mountain he had ever seen and growing larger, still. The grotesque creature opened a part of its skin, a toothless mouth for Michael.

Struggling to break free, though he was now far above the black waters and a fall would mean certain death, Michael could feel the slime coating more than just his body. It was beginning to seep into his mind, tainting it, feeding it horrors that no mortal was meant to see. The closer he was brought to this horrific mass the harder it became to think clearly.

Yes...it seemed as if the nightmares had finally reached their apex. As Michael stopped fighting, color began to return to his mind. Fear began to creep out of him as he was set down inside of the toothless maw of the beast. Looking around he saw beauty in the horror. Even inside, thousands of eyes were upon him, some blue...some black, some blinking and some staring forever through a lidless gaze. The walls, if one could call them walls, pulsated in time to whispers again. The shouts had faded, the whispers were all that remained. Wordless sounds in the back of the mind, repeated over and over again as the creature slowly drew itself back into the sea, leaving no trace behind that it had ever been.

Michael was Home.